

CHAPTER TEN

Saying Sorry and Meaning It

Marcus's stone was Aaliyah.

Specifically, Marcus's stone was the Saturday before Thanksgiving, when Aaliyah had — as three-year-olds will do — knocked over the LEGO castle Marcus had been building for two weeks. Marcus had been working on the towers all morning. Aaliyah had been told, three times, to stay away from the table. Aaliyah had not stayed away from the table. Aaliyah had stepped on a corner of it, and the castle had collapsed, and Marcus had — very fast, before his brain put on its shoes — picked up a single LEGO and thrown it at his sister.

It did not hit her hard. It hit her arm. She started crying. Marcus's mom had come into the room and seen the LEGO on the floor and Aaliyah crying and Marcus standing over the wreckage of the castle, and Marcus's mom had said, in a voice that was not yelling but was very, very serious, Marcus. We do not throw things at people. Ever. Marcus had said sorry. Right away. He had said it three or four times, fast, the way kids say sorry when they want the moment to be over. He had hugged Aaliyah. Aaliyah had stopped crying within two minutes, because three-year-olds do not hold on to things very long.

But here, six days later, Marcus was sitting on the carpet of Room 12, and he was carrying the LEGO around in his backpack.

He had not told anyone. He had not put it on the Mistake Wall. He had not written it in his journal. He had said sorry to Aaliyah and he had been forgiven by Aaliyah within ten seconds, and the whole household had moved on by dinnertime — but Marcus, by himself, had been thinking about that LEGO for six straight days.

On Tuesday morning, Ms. Calloway took Sammy out of the box.

"Friends," said Sammy, "today we are going to talk about saying sorry. About what makes a sorry a REAL sorry. And what makes a sorry not enough."

Sammy held up a chart.

A REAL SORRY HAS THREE PARTS 1. I NAME WHAT I DID.

2. I NAME HOW IT HURT.

3. I NAME WHAT WILL CHANGE.

"A real sorry," said Sammy, "is more than just the word sorry. The word is part of it. But the word is not all of it."

"First, you NAME WHAT YOU DID. You say it out loud. You do not say I'm sorry if you were upset. You say I am sorry that I — and then you say the thing. Because if you do not name it, the person you hurt cannot tell whether you understood what you did."

"Second, you NAME HOW IT HURT. You say that was unkind. That must have made you sad. That was scary. Because if you do not name how it hurt, the person you hurt cannot tell whether you understand them."

"Third — and this one is the most important — you NAME WHAT WILL CHANGE. You say next time, I will — and then you say the thing you will do differently. Because a sorry without a next time is just words. A sorry without a next time might be the same sorry you have to say again next week,

about the same thing. A sorry with a next time is a sorry that DOES something."

Marcus stared at the chart.

He was running, in his head, through the apology to Aaliyah. He had said I'm sorry about four times very fast. He had not named what he had done — he had not said I threw a LEGO at you and that was wrong. He had not named how it hurt — he had not said it hurt your arm and it scared you. He had not named what would change — he had not said next time, when something I built breaks, I am going to take a breath instead of throwing.

He had said sorry. But the sorry was missing two and a half of its three parts.

Marcus stayed quiet during Sammy's lesson. He stayed quiet during quiet work time. At recess he did not run around the way he usually did. He sat on the bench near the basketball hoop and thought.

When he got home that afternoon, he asked his mom if he could talk to Aaliyah for a minute. His mom said yes.

Aaliyah was on the living room floor with her stuffed elephant. Marcus sat down on the floor next to her. He was nervous. He had never done what he was about to do before.

"Aaliyah," he said.

She looked at him.

"I want to say sorry. For the LEGO. The one I threw."

Aaliyah, who had not thought about the LEGO in five and a half days, looked confused.

"It is okay," she said, because she had heard adults say it is okay and she had filed it as the thing to say when somebody says sorry. "Wait," said Marcus. "Let me say all of it. I threw a LEGO at you. That was wrong. It hit your arm and you cried and it must have hurt and it was probably scary. Next time the

thing I am building falls down, I am going to take a breath, instead of throwing. I am really sorry."

Aaliyah considered this.

"Okay," she said. And then, because Aaliyah is three and emotional events do not last long for her: "Can you play elephants with me?" Marcus played elephants with Aaliyah for forty-five minutes. He came back to school the next morning. Before the bell rang, he walked to the back of the room and added one new line to the Mistake Wall, under his September entry.

It said: I threw a LEGO at my sister Aaliyah in November. I said sorry the wrong way at first. Then I said sorry the right way, and I told her what I would do next time. Next time something falls down, I will take a breath.

He stepped back from the wall.

Ms. Calloway, who was over by her desk pretending to be busy with attendance — because she had seen him go to the wall and she did not want to make a big deal of it — looked up just for a moment, and caught his eye, and gave him a small private nod.

That afternoon, when Marcus got home, he reached into his backpack to look for his journal — and he realized, with a small surprised feeling in his chest, that the LEGO was not in his backpack anymore.

He had not put it down on purpose. He had not thought about putting it down.

It had just — fallen out, somewhere between the Mistake Wall and the bus, when he wasn't looking.

That is what a real sorry does. It empties the backpack. Not because the thing didn't happen — because you finally did the whole sorry, and the whole sorry is what the heavy part was for.